

Human frailty might ensure success of Enhanced Games

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It is impolite, even rude, to wish harm on a sporting event. Yet, I am pretty sure that a large percentage of fans might have wished that the Enhanced Games in Las Vegas would flop. And it did. The promised “Super Bowl of athletics, swimming and weightlifting” failed to impress where it mattered — in competition.

Drugs were allowed, banned equipment like special suits in swimming was allowed. I am not sure if cheating was allowed or if you could throw a brick at a rival if he was overtaking you, but perhaps the rules will get more refined in this annual event. Athletes who broke the existing world record earned a million dollars.

Hype propelled the Games till they actually began, and then nothing could save it.

Greek swimmer Kristian Gkolomeev swam 20.81 in the men’s 50m freestyle to shave 0.07 seconds off the world record held by Cameron McEvoy who responded with the tweet: “Seriously?! That’s all you got!” James “The Missile” Magnussen finished last out of four swimmers in the two races.

Spectators were told that athletes were taking “90.5% testosterone esters, 78.6% human growth hormone, 61.9% stimulants. EPO 40.5%.” By a happy coincidence, these drugs were being marketed and sold by The Enhanced Group.

So maybe the Games were a success in the arena that mattered most to its sponsors and backers — which included Donald Trump Jr who told the world the Games “represent the future — real competition, real



freedom, and real records being smashed.”

After the ‘record’ came in the final event of the day, Games’ CEO Maximilian Martin fell at Gkolomeev’s feet in relief and gratitude, saying modestly later, “We have changed the world tonight.”

Interestingly, while most of the 42 sprinters, swimmers and weightlifters were on banned substances, three athletes who were competing clean also won.

Fred Kerley (running clean, he said) won the men’s 100m in 9.97. It would have placed him last in the 2024 Olympic final. Kerley had boasted before the race that he would break Usain Bolt’s world record of 9.58. The

fastest drug-assisted time in the sprint still belongs to Ben Johnson who timed 9.79 at the Seoul Olympics (and was banned). It was later considered the dirtiest race in history with six runners having drug connections of some sort. Tempting as it is to write off the Enhanced Games as a disaster unlikely to be repeated, there are indications that human frailty might ensure its success. The money on offer is impressive. Hunter Armstrong, Olympic gold medallist, who competed clean and won the 50m backstroke received a quarter million dollars, more than 12 times a gold at the world championships fetches. Money will attract current and past champions. As one writer put it, “You can’t pay a mortgage with morals.”

But it isn’t all about the mortgage. Athletes taking risks with their health for our entertainment has a whiff of bored rich people paying an urchin money to run across a busy road to see if he can get to the other side.